

Everybody Wants a Piece of East Boston

Hola Cultura

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Eva Biscegli 0:01

East Boston is so criticized by the people and condemned and knocked down and everything, but everybody wants a piece of it. It's the truth. Everybody wants a piece of East Boston.

Renée Loth 0:11

The words environmental justice did not appear in the East Boston Community News at all in the 70s, but that's what the issues were. They were, why is this neighborhood – you know, a poor neighborhood, an immigrant neighborhood – why is this neighborhood so disproportionately carrying the burden of the rail and transportation infrastructure of the whole region?

Chris Marchi 0:32

So you've got a whole community. Let's say it's 45-50,000 people. Many of them have been here for generations. Some are newcomers. ... People tend to respond to environmental threats in different ways. A very common response is to shrug and say, "Well, there's nothing I can do about it." Another response is almost like Stockholm Syndrome, like, "Well, you know, what do you expect? We live near an airport." ... But a somewhat unusual response is to say, "Well, I'm never going to accept this. ... I'm going to always say my family and people around me, and everybody in this neighborhood deserves to have a healthy environment." To have that high standard, and to say, "We have to hold the Port Authority to a standard that they're not meeting." So that's an odd sort of role in a community where a lot of people say "oh, it's an airport," you know? A lot of people don't even notice impacts. If you ask them, they say, "I don't even hear the planes." On Facebook, they'll take these positions, like, "I like to smell the pollution!" They're just messing with you. So our role is to really try to describe what's going on to people, right? And also to let them know that it's not necessary.

Liliana Tirado Arteaga 1:42

Honestly, I heard about it for so long, but I never paid attention to it. And you know, as life tells you, you know, you learn things the hard way. A few years ago, I started feeling sick and tired. I was always very exhausted, very low energy. ... Well, I kept listening to my own body and I was diagnosed with colon cancer. And when I was diagnosed with colon cancer, I was very interested to find out where did it come from, and how much did I have to do to save my children. So that's when all the studies and genetic testing that we had done said that it was environmental caused. So then I started learning about it. ... And then, you know, obviously, I learned that I live close to the airport. ... And I learned about all the contamination in the environment and the fossil fuels. Everything that I have read or heard before that never paid attention, you know, the green [greenhouse] gasses and these and that, you know, you hear about it, but you don't really pay attention to it because it doesn't affect you. I think once something really affects you personally, then you start paying more attention to it, and ... saying "Wow, I should have known better." I heard about it, but that was my big hit when I got sick. So that's how I really got into being more of an advocate for clean air.

Chris Marchi 2:59

Working-class urban residents are still very, very low on the totem pole, and they don't have access to the processes. They don't have access to technical knowledge, right?

Kannan Thiruvengadam 3:11

If you think about it more systematically, the neighborhood has been discovered because of its convenient access to the city and other kinds of nice things about the neighborhood. You know, it's eclectic, it's diverse, and lot of interesting restaurants, nice views. So many things were interesting, the subways available. So, you could easily ride the subway to downtown in 5 minutes - 10 minutes. So many attractive things. So, people started moving in here and because once that has happened, a lot of land is now being developed that was not originally developed and was abandoned.

Liliana Tirado Arteaga 3:48

I've been living here for the past 25 years, maybe around there or even more. And honestly, like, the community has changed. You know, we were like very 90% Latino, and now it's changing. You know, we are getting, as you know, a lot of developments in the community and the population is changing a little bit. Still, the majority of the population is Latino, so it's basically minorities.

Kannan Thiruvengadam 4:16

The reason Covid even got so bad in East Boston. ... So, one of the train lines that had a pretty good occupancy ridership even after the shutdown happened was Blue Line, because a lot of people from East Boston were traveling to various parts of Greater Boston because they were doing essential work. If they weren't essential workers themselves, their work was essential to their lives. That's how they were making ends meet. Even that became difficult once the offices shut down, and they couldn't go to do cleaning work or whatever. So that meant that there is no money to pay rent or buy food. It's also that the displacement has been going on in East Boston for so long that some people who are displaced out of the neighborhood, but others were displaced internally. So, if you had a friend in the neighborhood, you would say, "Can I move in with you?" Or if you had an extended family member in the neighborhood, you would say to them, "Can I move in with you?"

Liliana Tirado Arteaga 5:19

So today we're talking about 58% Latino in the demographics, but then you think about it, and 58% of Latinos, we live in an area that does not meet the federal air quality standards, compared to other people who have the luxury of having an amazing environment, an amazing air quality. So, on average, I don't think we produce that many [greenhouse gasses]. I talked to a lot of the families, they don't even have a car, And I was like, okay, so you don't drive, you take public transportation, this and that, and you still have the worst air quality possible for your children and your family. So that's pretty sad.